

Maturation

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MATURATION

It is well for the world that in most of us, by the age of thirty, the character has set like plaster, and will never soften again.

—WILLIAM JAMES

I FIRST INTERVIEWED the Grant Study men in 1967, when I was thirty-three and they were in their late forties. I've always respected William James, and for a while those early encounters seemed to confirm his contention that character is set by thirty. But watching the men change in real time quickly persuaded me that about this, at least, he was mistaken. Lesson Four of the Grant Study is that people really do grow. Having learned it, I now argue with friends not about whether personalities change in adulthood, but about how best to measure the changes, and about what a person should be at the end of life that he was not at the beginning. That is, I ponder models of maturation, and hope that the Grant Study will, in the fullness of time, contribute to the construction of a better one than any we yet possess.

Developmental psychology textbooks still suggest, by omission if not by active assertion, that maturation stops at twenty—thirty at the latest. One major work maintained as recently as 2010, “It appears that individuals change very little in personality (either self-reported or rated by spouses) over periods of up to thirty years and over the age range 20 to 90.”

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It's true that an oak tree's leaves don't vary much as the tree ages—their shape and character are inherent fixed traits. But that doesn't mean that the tree itself remains the same. On the contrary, the grandeur and complexity of a well-growing oak do develop with age, enhanced increasingly by time and circumstances until the tree is damaged or dies. The color of the wine in a bottle of Château Margaux doesn't change much as the years pass, either—but its character sure does, and so does its price.

Over the last seventy-five years, the Study staff has been influenced by at least six models that try to encompass developmental elaborations such as these. The first was the *lieben und arbeiten* model famously attributed to Freud by Erikson, which equated maturation with a deepening capacity for love and for work. 2 The Menninger Clinic's brilliant research psychologist Lester Luborsky turned Freud's epigram into the model of development used in the clinic's thirty-plus-year Psychotherapy Research Project. 3 His scale, slightly tweaked, year Psychotherapy Research Project was eventually enshrined in DSM-IV as Axis V of the American Psychiatric Association's definition of mental health. 4 When I was doing those first interviews, I used it to assess maturity in the Grant Study men, and reflections of it remain in the Decathlon and the Adult Adjustment scales (Appendix D). 5

There's a problem with *arbeiten und lieben* as a comprehensive model of adult development, however. Maturation means development forward over time, but as the decades passed, the men's standing in those two realms was as changeable as the weather. Only five (9 percent) of the fifty-five men who scored in the top third in Adult Adjustment (which included assessments of success in love and in work) at forty-seven remained in the top third for all of the subsequent ratings (at fifty to sixty-five years, at sixty-five to eighty years, and for the Decathlon). Sixteen (29 percent) actually scored in the bottom third during one of those next three periods. Periods of success at work and at love came and went unsystematically and according to circumstance, and there were no universally discernible processes of “deepening” with age and experience. This model did not tell us enough about how people “grow up.”

At thirty-four I was only just becoming aware of how complex a concept maturity is. Furthermore, it means different things at different times and to different people. As my acquaintance with the Grant men (and with myself) advanced, Erik Erikson's model of psychosocial development seemed increasingly more to the point:

Human personality, in principle, develops according to steps predetermined in the growing person's readiness to be driven toward, to be aware of, and to interact with a widening social radius. 6

We worked with this model a great deal for my first ten years with the Study, and it is the one that most deeply informs this chapter. 7 Maturation along Eriksonian lines implies a growing capacity to tolerate difference and a growing sense of responsibility for others; it is the evolution of teenage self-centeredness into the disinterested empathy of a grandparent. Unlike success at love and work, Erikson's developmental achievements are relatively independent of surroundings. They appear and endure in predictable ways. Barring the kinds of organic damage that diminish functional capacity, they do not get lost; people are not seen to revert to earlier stages of maturation. This makes Erikson's model, and the ones that follow, a more convincing conception of adult growth processes. 8

My third model of maturity focuses on the development of social and emotional intelligence. This is the model that best addresses the way our involuntary coping styles develop over time, becoming, if we are fortunate, ever more empathic and less narcissistic—that is, ever more conducive to rewarding relationships. It makes room not only for the expanding effects of experience and psychological growth, but also for certain relevant aspects of brain development. The development of adaptational capacity is a major interest of mine; it was one of the interests that brought me to the Grant Study, and it dominated my research and writing through my sixtieth year. I will discuss adaptational capacity in detail in Chapter 8.

A fourth model of maturity, honored in Hindu cultures, holds that the task of the grandfather is to retire to the forest to tend to his spiritual life, turning secular preoccupations over to his son. Adam Newman's story illustrates how a man's emotional life can evolve away from personal passions and toward trust, love, and compassion. The attractiveness of this model has been enhanced by recent advances in brain imaging and neuroscience, which locate the emotions traditionally linked with spirituality—awe, hope, compassion, love, trust, gratitude, joy, forgiveness—in their neuroanatomic and evolutionary contexts as biological reality, not abstract sentiment. 9 This work was becoming known as I was approaching seventy and beginning to contemplate my own retirement. I have found it increasingly compelling since.

My fifth model is the one espoused by developmental neuroanatomists such as Paul Yakovlev and Francine Benes. 10 It focuses not on socioemotional growth per se, but on the emotional changes that accompany changes in the brain, the development of which does not come to a halt at sixteen. Neuroanatomists have demonstrated that there is increasing myelination in the brain between twenty and sixty years of age. (Myelin is the substance that insulates neurons, increasing the efficiency of their electrical functioning.) The net effect of this development is that cognition and the passions work increasingly in concert. That is old news to car rental agencies. They know very well that forty-year-old drivers are more likely, and more able, to think before they act than eighteen-year-olds. Developmental science has now caught up with them enough to know that this is thanks to continued integration of the impulsive limbic system and the reflective frontal lobes, which advances in brain imaging have newly made accessible to study. Robert Waldinger, the current director of the Grant Study, is pursuing this model of development.

The sixth and most recent model of maturity envisions the development of wisdom as the goal and pinnacle of adult development. Sociologist Monika Ardelt at the University of Florida has used the lifetime studies of the College men to study empirically the age-dependent nature of that mysterious and fateful quality. 11 More about this shortly.

The life history of Charles Boatwright, which appears later in this chapter, encompasses all six of these models. And so it should be, for all of them apply to all of us, if not all equally usefully at all times. Maturity means something different to us in youth than it does later, whether we are researchers or just individuals living our lives. Certainly different aspects of maturity came to salience for me as I watched the Grant Study men aging. But I can't separate that from the changing awareness that came with my own increasing years and, I hope, wisdom. Or from the fact that science is growing and maturing too; even now it is capable of feats that were unthinkable ten years ago, and its lifespan is much longer than ours. In this chapter, however, I will concentrate on Erik Erikson's conception of adult development, and some Grant Study-related revisions to it.

ERIKSON'S MODEL: THEME AND VARIATIONS

In *As You Like It*, Shakespeare portrayed everything after middle age as decay. Freud, like many psychologists, ignored adult development entirely. It took Erikson, who as a young man wanted to be an artist, to envision all of life as forward motion and growth. He imagined adult development as a staircase, ascending from the adolescent task of Identity formation to the young adult's movement away from dependence on parents to Intimacy with peers, and then from there to the preoccupations of older adults—Generativity (looking after others) and eventually Integrity (maintaining

equanimity in the face of death).

Carol Gilligan, a scholar of women's development, has suggested to me a provocative alternative image of this process. 12 Gilligan thinks not of a staircase, but of the expanding ripples produced when a stone is dropped into a pond. Each older ripple encompasses, yet never obliterates, the circles emanating from the younger ones. Her image is as vivid as Erikson's, but it engages a less goal-directed—a less stereotypically masculine—concept of how people grow, and a compelling evocation of Erikson's model of adult development as an ever-widening social circle and moral compass.

I have made two modifications of my own to Erikson's model, distinguishing from his stages two others, which I have called Career Consolidation and Guardianship (or, in previous publications, Keeper of the Meaning).

Erikson established his model, now very well known, in *Childhood and Society*. 13 But brilliant though it was, Erikson's "stages," like most other outlines of adulthood, were armchair intuitions. It is only in the twenty-first century that adult lives and lifetimes, observed prospectively from their beginnings to their ends, have become available for viewing as developing wholes. 14 The *in vivo* empirical study of adult development dates back just forty years, to when Jack Block, Glen Elder, Robert White, and Charles McArthur and I began (in four separate efforts) to look at prospectively studied lives of adults in midlife. 15

I must make clear too that in adult development, stage is a metaphor. It is a popular one, thanks to its wide use by Erikson and others. But it is not descriptively accurate. Clearly defined developmental stages can be seen in embryology, in endocrinology, and perhaps in the process of cognitive development that Piaget and his students observed in children. But adult development as we saw it in Study subjects, and as I will describe it here, is a much less tidy process.

Let me therefore begin my exposition of Erikson's model by noting that developmental task is a more useful concept than stage, and that—in a process that I'm sure is familiar by now—I assessed mastery of the so-called stages of adult development by tracking the specific accomplishments of psychosocial maturation that I believe reflect and underlie them. 16 I was trying to concretize in an enduring and statistically useful way life situations that are usually described as abstractions, intuitions, and value judgments.

Identity. Erikson calls the first developmental stage of adulthood Identity vs. Role Diffusion. For working and research purposes, I modify Erikson's terminology to Identity vs. Identity Diffusion, and define it as follows: to achieve Identity is to separate from social, economic, and ideological dependence upon one's parents. The specific tasks I used to define the achievement of Identity were: to live independently of family of origin, and to be self-supporting.

Identity is not egocentricity. Nor is it a simple matter of running away from home, acquiring a driver's license, or even getting married, as the adolescent trope would have it. There's a world of difference between the instrumental act of running away and the developmental achievement of learning to distinguish one's own values from surrounding ones, and remaining true to them even when life is at its most contradictory and confusing. Identity does not imply rejection of one's past; on the contrary, it derives very much from identification with and internalization of important childhood figures and surrounds, as well as from independent experience in adult life. But it does involve choices about where and how one places one's loyalties.

Some of the Study men never achieved separation from their families of origin or the other institutions that formed them. In our research, we considered this a failure to achieve Identity. In middle life, these individuals remained emotionally dependent on childhood supports, and never moved far enough out into the world to embark upon such voluntary new loyalties as an occupation, an intimate friendship, or a love partner. Although they did not usually come to psychiatric attention, many of them, as they grew older, viewed themselves as incomplete. Some possessed full insight into how little they shared the usual adult preoccupations of guiding the young and trying to keep the world spinning smoothly on its axis. Francis DeMille in Chapter 8 struggled for a long time with identity issues. But the window of opportunity on Identity stays open for a long time, and its ripple keeps expanding into old age. Separation and individuation are lifelong processes.

Intimacy. Erikson calls his second adult stage Intimacy vs. Isolation. I defined the specific task of Intimacy as the capacity to live with another person in an emotionally attached, interdependent, and committed relationship for ten years or more. According to that criterion, a man could achieve Intimacy at any point in his life, and indeed, there was a lot of variation in when this task was accomplished. One of the issues I'll address as we go on is what the variability of

Eriksonian achievement means in adult development. We'll also consider at some length in the next chapter the difference between Intimacy as a developmental task and intimacy as a relational aptitude. For now, however, I'll note that you can't establish an attached, committed, and interdependent relationship until you've moved out of your parents' world and ensconced yourself in the world of your peers. Mastery of Intimacy depends on first mastering Identity.

A few words of explanation about my criterion. True intimacy is notoriously difficult to measure, as we are all shockingly reminded when a friend's apparently solid marriage goes on the rocks. Ten years of committed, interdependent, laughing marriage is a reasonable approximation of Intimacy for most people living here and now, but marriage itself is not the point. There are intimate friendships; there are nonintimate marriages; there are love relationships that cannot be consummated in marriage. In stable homosexual relationships, or in highly interdependent institutions like convents, where rules for communal living take the place of dyadic bonding, criteria for Intimacy other than marriage may be needed. When issues of that kind arose, I took them into account. I also took into account the fact that the Grant Study came out of an intolerant era, which made the achievement of Intimacy difficult for some. Only two of the Grant Study men achieved stable homosexual relationships, which were counted as achievements of Intimacy; the other five who acknowledged a homosexual preference did not make lasting intimate commitments. For several single women in the Terman sample, Intimacy was achieved with a very close lifelong woman friend, who may or may not have been a sexual partner.

The arbitrary determination of ten years was a piece of pragmatic reductionism designed to facilitate the assignment of a numerical score. On the one hand, nothing lasts forever; on the other, ten years is long enough to distinguish a "real" relationship from a clearly illusory one.

Career Consolidation. I observed repeatedly that some men who successfully established identities within (and then beyond) their families of origin nevertheless failed to accomplish the same thing in the world of work. Accordingly, I took the step of distinguishing career maturation from the other aspects of identity formation to create a separate stage that I now call Career Consolidation vs. Role Diffusion. As I have explained in detail elsewhere, Erikson conflated the tasks of mastery of identity formation and mastery of career identification. 17

I defined the specific tasks of Career Consolidation as commitment, compensation, contentment, and competence. These four words distinguish a career from a job. By this I do not mean that a lawyer has a career and a janitor has a job. Prestige has nothing to do with the presence of those four characteristics. You can be a competent and well-compensated physician like Carlton Tarryton (below), but if you are so contemptuous about the value of medicine that you turn to Christian Science for your own care, you do not have a career. Men and women in hunter-gatherer societies can bring commitment and enjoyment to the tasks at hand, and lawyers in our society can work without either.

Career consolidation engages a paradox. Selflessness, in the conventional sense of magnanimity or altruism, depends on a sturdy and reliable sense of self. Commitment to a career (and establishing a robust sense of career identity) is an essential developmental task, and it is in large degree a selfish one. That is why society tolerates the ineffable egocentricity of graduate students, young housewives, and business trainees. Only when developmental "self-ishness" has been achieved are we reliably capable of giving the self away as professors, mothers-of-the-bride, and managers. Career Consolidation has roots in Intimacy as well as Identity. Like Intimacy, it combines the necessary self-absorption of young adulthood with the commitment to others necessary to merit a paycheck.

The process that leads today's medical students through internship, residency, and fellowship to professional autonomy is not so very different from the medieval guild structure that took a youth from apprentice to journeyman to master weaver. Young people have always been taught their craft by older practitioners, and then encouraged to make their own individual contributions. That sense of unique competence was considered the culmination of professional formation; it is the culmination of Career Consolidation as well. As one of the Terman women, a writer, put it, "Being home and being married wasn't sufficient. . . . I wanted to secure my sense of competence, to be good at something, acquire a measurable skill, something that I could say 'I have learned this, I am good at this, I can do this, I know this.' "

In tracking the achievement of Career Consolidation I had to take into account that societies constrain the way men and women achieve this sense of competence. The Terman women, for example, were born around 1910; they were in middle school before their mothers could vote. There were limited occupational possibilities open to these very gifted women. I therefore deemed a woman to have mastered Career Consolidation if she was committed, competent, and

content at her work, even if she was not always compensated for it in money. Similarly, in the twenty-first century there are men who have consolidated careers as househusbands. The story of Charles Boatwright, coming up in a moment, offers yet another take on Career Consolidation.

Generativity. Erikson's third stage is Generativity vs. Stagnation, which I define as the wish and the capacity to foster and guide the next generations (not only one's own adolescents) to independence. The specific task by which I defined Generativity was the assumption of sustained responsibility for the growth and well-being of others still young enough to need care but old enough to make their own decisions. Generativity, of course, may also include community building and other forms of leadership, but not, to my mind, such pursuits as raising children, painting pictures, and growing crops. These are valuable and creative tasks, but they do not demand the ego skills required to care for "adolescents" of any age. Consider the incredible sensitivity required of famed Scribner's editor Maxwell Perkins, trying to protect the self-centered and self-destructive F. Scott Fitzgerald from his folly while at the same time nurturing his literary genius. As my school-principal aunt once explained: "You can always tell who is headmistress by who moves the most furniture."

Guardianship. In this second modification of Erikson's schema, I organized distinctive aspects of Generativity or Integrity (as he saw it) into a separate stage that I have discussed in earlier works as Keeper of the Meaning vs. Rigidity, but am now calling Guardianship vs. Hoarding (see Chapter 11). Andrew Carnegie, a Guardian, built libraries with his life's savings; the Pharaohs built pyramids.

Generative people care for others in a direct, forward-oriented relationship—mentor to mentee, teacher to student. They are caregivers. Guardians are care takers. They take responsibility for the cultural values and riches from which we all benefit, offering their concern beyond specific individuals to their culture as a whole; they engage a social radius that extends beyond their immediate personal surround. They are curators, looking to the past to preserve it for the future. We tracked this developmental achievement by such curatorial activities, which will be exemplified in many of the life stories that follow.

In his writings, Erikson sometimes fails to distinguish between the care that characterizes Generativity and the wisdom that characterizes Guardianship (and which he has ascribed, I believe incorrectly, to Integrity). Generativity has to do with the people one chooses to take care of; Guardianship entails a dispassionate and less personal world view. It is possible to imagine care without wisdom, but not wisdom without care—and indeed, in adult development, the capacity to care does precede wisdom. Wisdom requires not only concern, but also the appreciation of irony and ambiguity, and enough perspective and dispassion not to take sides. These are ego skills that come relatively late in life. They are the fruit of long experience and they sometimes conflict with the more generative forms of caring, which may imply sticking up for one person against another. Guardianship is the disinterested even-handedness of the judge who protects the processes of the law in the interests of all of us, as opposed to the advocacy of the generative lawyer, who uses those processes in the service of the client he protects. This is the difference in attitude between the successfully generative Reagan's relentless demonization of the "Evil Empire" and the guardian Lincoln's Second Inaugural plea for malice toward none and charity for all.

Wisdom is often defined in abstract terms: discernment, judgment, discretion, prudence. But it is a developmental achievement, just like the capacity to thrive away from one's mother, or to live harmoniously with a spouse, or to be a forbearing parent to one's entitled teenagers. The task of the Guardian is to honor the vast competing realities of past, present, and future, and to find, as the judge does in *The Merchant of Venice*, the true wisdom that is a fusion of caring and justice.

One fifty-five-year-old College man described in a letter some aspects of his development into Guardianship. He said that he was feeling a sense of broadening. "I have finally come through to a realization of what is of critical importance for our future—that we finally come to live in harmony with nature and our natural environment, not in victory over it. . . . The earlier period was one of comparative innocence and youthful exuberance—a celebration more of my physical powers, of unfettered freedom. Those powers I now celebrate are more of an intellectual variety, somewhat tinged by experience of the world; in a way my lately-acquired knowledge . . . is not an unalloyed blessing, but a burden in some respects."

Integrity. Erikson called his final life stage Integrity vs. Despair. Integrity is the capacity to come to terms constructively with our pasts and our futures in the face of inevitable death. It is a demanding achievement that requires the embrace of contradiction: How do we maintain hope when the inevitability of our end is staring us in the face? The very old have less control and fewer choices than they had when they were younger, but in confronting this reality they may become great masters of Niebuhr's beloved prayer: "God grant me the serenity to accept the things I cannot change; courage to change the things I can; and the wisdom to know the difference."

Integrity differs from the other Eriksonian stages in that (while Integrity issues are perhaps most common in the very old) it is not associated exclusively with any one chronological time of life. It is a developmental response to the anticipation of death, which illness or ill fortune may bring to the fore at any age.

Integrity is a life task I have not yet experienced, and instead of trying to describe it I will recuse myself and let the Study members show what it feels like to them. One Study member asserted, "I think it is enormously important to the next generation that we be happy into old age—happy and confident—not necessarily that we are right but that it is wonderful to persist in our search for meaning and rectitude. Ultimately, that is our most valuable legacy—the conviction that life is and has been worthwhile right up to the limit." Another man dying of prostate cancer explained to me that whenever he had a sudden pain, he could never know if it was "simply old age or another metastasis. . . . But I am a fatalist; when it comes it comes. . . . Each of us was born of this earth, nurtured by it; and each of us will return to the earth."

Perhaps it was a Terman woman, very near death, who embraced the concept of Integrity most succinctly in an explanation of what life was like for her since becoming bedridden: "My accomplishments since then have been to stay alive and alert and to be thankful for all the blessings that have been mine." A recent questionnaire had inquired about her aims for the future. Instead of checking whether it was important for her to "die peacefully," she wrote beside that box, "Who has a choice? Death comes when it comes." Instead of checking whether it was important for her "to make a contribution to society" she wrote beside the box, "In a minor way I have already done so." Instead of fruitlessly complaining that she was of no further use, she—empathically to those around her—reflected the inner peace that came of having paid her dues. That's not chutzpah, that's wisdom.

AN ERIKSONIAN LIFE

My first efforts in 1971 to unravel adult development focused on Erikson's stages of Intimacy and Generativity.¹⁸ At that time, my favorite illustration of adult development was a fifty-year-old Study member, George Bancroft. Asked how he had grown in stature between college and middle life, Bancroft replied, "From age twenty to thirty I learned how to get along with my wife; from age thirty to forty I learned how to be a success at my job; and since I have been forty, I have worried less about myself and more about the children." That summed up succinctly everything I (then) thought there was to adult development. It was the map of world as I knew it at thirty-seven: grown-ups mastered Generativity, and then they died.

But as the decades passed I was increasingly aware that this was not an accurate life map. It took me a while to see what was going on; I was a man in my early fifties studying men in their late sixties, and the fact that they were still growing was more than I (or the fifty-year-old Erikson before me) could readily appreciate. We all needed more time. This was the gift the Grant Study gave over and over again. The ensuing years afforded me both a wider theoretical compass and an expanded experience of my own development, as well as many more chances to observe the men. One man in particular. As I sailed off toward terra incognita, my favorite guide to adult development continued to be Professor Bancroft.

At fifty, as you've seen, Bancroft was a generative Mr. Chips. He looked after his own children, and he looked after the history students at his small college. But not so long after that he became dean of the college, and, I noticed, he suddenly had all the students to attend to, to say nothing of the care of his entire young faculty. I could also see that that was a different order of responsibility; it was no longer Bancroft's job to manage individuals' day-to-day development, but instead to establish the kind of atmosphere in which everyone could thrive. His social radius had expanded greatly, and he was no longer functioning as a parent, but as an elder.

For a while Bancroft was still too busy “worrying about the children” to write books. At research universities, writing books is a top priority, because career development and ultimately tenure depend on it. But at small colleges and high schools, book-writing tends to be a retirement activity, like genealogy and town histories. And so it was for Bancroft. At seventy he retired. His focus, which had shifted from teaching history to tending his school now shifted again—this time to writing history. His attention moved even further outward as he began to fill the very role for which, in my opinion, evolution permits grandparents to survive. Once older adults can no longer procreate children, their task has been to preserve the culture, to become what anthropologists call “firestick elders.” That is what Bancroft did. Between seventy and ninety he wrote five books that for generations to come will bring America’s past to life for her new citizens. He had turned his attention to recollection and preservation, and at last I was able to recognize this, in him and in others. Henry Ford, at age seventy, founded the Greenfield Village Museum to preserve the beauty of a style of life that his creation of the Model T assembly line had helped to destroy. Charles Lindbergh devoted his life after seventy to the preservation of Stone Age cultures that his charting of intercontinental air routes had begun to obliterate. They too became guardians of what seemed to them most meaningful in life.

Bancroft always did have a special way of making development real and visible to me. In 2010, when he was eighty-eight, I asked him that same question of almost forty years before, about how he had grown in stature. (I was fishing for clues about how his transformation into Guardianship had come about.) We were talking on the phone, and my question caught him by surprise. But his answer surprised me even more. “You learn a little more about yourself and you learn how to be alone . . . in part so that you can face death without fear. As the saying goes, ‘When you grow old, you get to know women and doctors.’ All my male friends have died. . . . You let your wife learn about you. . . . I have to go for a driving test, to see if the world will be safer if I give up my license.” And there you have it—an extraordinary description of Erikson’s final task of Integrity.

For Bancroft, as for every other American adolescent, the acquisition of that driver’s license had once been a critical first venture into adulthood, part of the mastery of Identity and the world outside his parents’ house. Seventy years later, the developmental task of Integrity was about being able to give the precious license up, and, if necessary, to adopt with equanimity Job’s mantra: “The Lord giveth, the Lord taketh away. Blessed be the name of the Lord.”

THE LIFE OF CHARLES BOATWRIGHT

I didn’t think about wisdom as a model of maturity until I was over sixty-five. I didn’t think much about Charles Boatwright, either. When I was doing my work on good and bad outcomes in the 1970s, his marriage was a shambles, and even in his mid-fifties he seemed to me occupationally feckless. At that point in my life I didn’t see much to exemplify optimum adult development at that point in his, and I let him slide gently off my radar.

In 2009, however, when I was seventy-five, Monika Ardelt pointed out to me that Charles Boatwright had scored higher than any man in the Grant Study on her measure of wisdom. 19 That got my attention, all right, and I looked at him closely for the first time in years. Boatwright’s Decathlon score was 7 out of 10; only 3 percent of Grant Study men scored higher. In fact, late in life he was scoring high on every measure of maturity I had ever devised. Here was yet one more demonstration that my black-and-white, good-or-bad predictions at age forty-seven were unreliable. What on earth had happened?

I thought back to those early years. I’d found Boatwright’s file tedious going. His lack of career commitment was one of the reasons I’d scored him as a potential “bad outcome” in my old black-and-white days. It was easy to marshal other evidence of failure, too: a divorce, an estrangement from his daughter, a drifting son. Yet he wrote constantly of his good fortune in leading such a wonderful life, and exclamation points punctuated his enthusiasm.

Here’s how he answered a Study questionnaire when he was forty-nine. How had he grown in stature and matured between the ages of twenty and fifty? Between twenty and thirty, Boatwright said, “I learned humility and how to work hard and to dedicate myself to others. I learned to love.” Between thirty and forty, “I went to graduate school and matured rapidly in business and in the community. I became an important cog in the community. I was a flaming do-gooder. I learned further to take responsibility.” Between forty and fifty, “I feel a marked change has come over me. I have learned to be more kind, and have more empathy. I have learned to be tolerant. I have a much better understanding of life, its meaning and purposes. I’ve left the church, but in many ways I feel more Christian. I now understand . . . the old, the meek, the hard worker, and most of all children.” Reading this in 1974, I was inclined to roll my eyes. I thought I

recognized the kind of premature selflessness that cloaks a lack of clear identity—a series of early efforts to deny his own needs and project them onto others—and Boatwright’s failures at Intimacy and Career Consolidation, like Camille’s, seemed to confirm that. However, I was dead wrong.

Dr. Maren Batalden, the astute internist who did some of the post-retirement interviews for us, had a similar reaction to Boatwright many years later. She visited him when he was seventy-nine. When she asked him about his mood, he gushed, “Optimistic, optimistic. Pollyanna, Pollyanna.” Even Boatwright did not seem quite able to believe his own words.

But Batalden changed her mind, which should have alerted me even before Monika Ardelt did. She recounted that while transcribing the tapes of her interview with the seventy-nine-year-old Boatwright, she had felt “critical of his contradictions and his ‘methinks the lady doth protest too much’ assertions of his good luck.” But as she began to write her report, she suddenly found that she had to contradict herself. “In fact, my experience with Boatwright was delightful . . . interesting and interested, gracious, charming, and engaged. I was impressed with his voracious hunger for learning, which obviously keeps him vital. He is, I think, remarkably effective in actually getting what he wants. After fifteen years of gradually progressive discontent in the staid corporate world, he had leaped into debt and boldly returned to the rhythm of life he felt himself most suited to. Without really consolidating a career, he seems to be in a state of unequivocal Generativity.”

Still, it wasn’t until ten years later that Ardelt’s comment made me look again at Boatwright’s record. And when I did, I recognized that it wasn’t he who had suddenly matured. It was I. I had finally learned that hope and optimism are not emotions to be dismissed lightly; perhaps this was a reflection of some spiritual growth of my own. And while it’s easy to scoff at Pollyanna stereotypes, the wisdom of Pollyanna herself—the real young heroine of the book named for her—is nothing to laugh at. 20

My years of studying adaptive styles had shown me that projection sometimes evolves into altruism. But when? When does a miserable Albanian teenager turn into Mother Teresa? Would Nelson Mandela have served himself better, locked away on Robben Island, by bemoaning his helplessness and planning revenge? Or was he wiser to do just as he did—tell his captors funny jokes while maintaining the invincible hope that they’d “walk hand in hand some day”? It can take a lifetime even to formulate questions like that, and for me, where Charles Boatwright was concerned, it did.

His life illustrates five of the Study’s six models for maturation: increasing capacities for working and loving, widening of the social radius, development of mature defenses, attention to the spiritual as well as the material, and growing wisdom. The sixth model, brain maturation, will have to wait for a lifetime study of neuroimaging—a study that probably won’t be feasible until close to the end of the twenty-first century.

Boatwright came from a distinguished New England academic family. Both his parents had taught at the college level before assuming more conventional 1920s careers. His father became a stockbroker, and his mother was a homemaker who was active in unpaid social service work. Throughout his life, Boatwright enjoyed a warm and loving relationship with his father, mother, and younger sister, and with a close-knit extended family. By 1940 the family was wealthy and owned three houses, but Boatwright inherited a commitment to social welfare from his mother, and he boasted that his father had “started out from absolutely nothing in the way of a job and worked his way up to the top.” The hardworking father was not remote. He made sure that he spent time with his family.

From the very beginning of the Study, Boatwright appeared to be well adjusted. His childhood received high marks from independent raters blind to his future, even though his father would manifest very serious mental illness by the middle of Boatwright’s adolescence. When Boatwright was twenty, his mother described him as “very affectionate, sensitive but with a great deal of courage and determination. Gets on remarkably well with both young and old. . . . Has never been a problem in any sense of the word. Good self-control. . . . Always made friends easily but was always able to amuse himself.” When he was a child his mother would spank him and put him in a large closet for punishment. When she returned, she would find that he was “entirely content and had usually found something to play with.” Sophisticates may scorn optimists—consider the scorn Voltaire heaped upon Dr. Pangloss—but the Grant Study suggests that Martin Seligman’s research is right on target. Optimism is far more often a blessing than a curse. 21

After college, Boatwright was rejected for military service because of poor eyesight. He found employment in the Brooklyn Navy Yard, equipping ships with radar and repairing radar equipment. In the Study questionnaires he described his work with great satisfaction. Then he moved to Vermont as “assistant manager,” but really caretaker, of a tree farm owned by his father.

At nineteen Boatwright said of his father, “We do everything together, practically,” and of his family, “We all get along beautifully together.” This statement was typical of his tendency to see the glass as always half full. From Boatwright’s fifteenth year through about his thirty-fifth, his father was racked with manic-depressive illness, and became a very difficult and sometimes cruelly critical man.

Boatwright’s marriage was a similar story. He married at twenty-two, and stayed married for thirty years. And he always rated his marriage as happy until his early fifties, when I was deep in my process of classifying the men as good or bad outcomes. That was the year he wrote to the Study that his wife had been very unhappy living in Vermont, that she was in love with an old friend, and that she had decided to leave. “It’s all so confining. I feel wasted and unused,” he wrote. “I don’t have really much love or feeling for her, and that is terribly hard on her too.” A year later he was divorced, and I was dismissing him once again as a Pollyanna and a master of denial.

Thirty years later, I have changed my tune. Now I can see that Boatwright remained committed to his wife as long as he could. Even in the throes of divorce he relied on empathy rather than blame: “She is a wonderful person, but so negative with everything.” We learned much later that over those last five years she had been increasingly incapacitated by alcoholism, but Boatwright did not reveal this fact until he was over seventy. (In retrospect, his temporary difficulties with his children may have been a result of their mother’s alcoholism.) An observer might complain that he was in denial, but he was not blind to the situation. It would be more precise to say that, true to his character, he was taking responsibility for his wife’s failings. Resentments, however justified, are rarely a source of happiness, and Boatwright was a natural adherent to the principle that forgiveness is better than revenge.

Similarly, Boatwright stayed close to his father, remaining appreciative and protective of him throughout his illness. On his deathbed, Boatwright’s father said to him, “I don’t understand why you were always so nice to me.” Batalden asked him about that too, and Boatwright replied, “He was nice to me. He took an interest in me, and everything I did. He meant to be a good man. He really did.” For Charles Boatwright, lemons were mostly the sine qua non of lemonade. Gratitude, and the mature adaptive coping style of sublimation, came naturally to him. Some Grant Study men went to look after Germany and Japan after the end of World War II; they had to be sent home because their anger broke through their ersatz altruism. But there was nothing ersatz about Boatwright.

While in Vermont, Boatwright had been active in building up a lumber cooperative, a farmer’s cooperative, an egg cooperative, and a central high school. He made extra money as journalist, milk deliverer, carpenter/painter, accountant for a filling station, and artificial inseminator of cattle. At that time, the early 1950s, Clark Heath noted that Boatwright had “persistent difficulty establishing a career,” but he thought him to be, nevertheless, one of the “most stable and successful men” in the Study. Heath was a very wise man and nearing his own retirement, and this was a paradox that it took the Study (or at least me) a lifetime to resolve.

Now I understand that community-building is a career of its own—one of the really great ones. But when I began with the Grant Study in my thirties, I was too deep into the “selfish” phase of my own career consolidation to understand what Charles Boatwright was about. I could see that he worked hard throughout his life, but as he moved from one job to another, it was hard to tell where his commitment or his competence lay. Clearly he didn’t see his work as a career, yet—I realized once I stopped dismissing his optimism—he found meaning and success in whatever he undertook. It took me a long time to understand that the career that Boatwright consolidated was looking after others more needy than himself. Even in college his chief extracurricular activity had been Phillips Brooks House, Harvard’s social service organization. His career was not all about him. Pollyanna’s wasn’t about her, either.

In his fifties, abandoning caution, Boatwright left the corporate world of his post-Vermont forties, and borrowed the money to follow a dream. He bought a boatyard. At the age of fifty-six, he married the widow (and mother of three sons) of his business partner in that venture, who had died suddenly and tragically the year before. According to both spouses, this marriage has been happy for the last thirty-five years. In the 1980 biennial questionnaire, he wrote characteristically of his second marriage, “Her children needed me very badly. So in January 1978 we were married. It has been perfect for

me. No one has ever healed me with such love. And in return I have come to love her completely. We have been enormously happy.”

Characteristically too, Boatwright devoted himself to his stepsons. “Being a stepfather has an enormous number of problems, but I seemed to have coped well. They all call me Dad. We are a very loving and close family. I’m an enormously lucky fellow.” True, Boatwright had told us that he was happy with his first wife the first time around. But this time his second wife, who has had her own private interview, confirms how happy she is with him. When Boatwright was sixty-one, an interviewer asked him what pleased him most about his wife. “He said, ‘She loves me,’ ” the interviewer wrote. “He beamed, and his face lit up.”

When he was seventy-nine, Boatwright told Batalden that he and his wife gave more to charity than they should. Most of their giving, he explained, goes into land conservation—that is, preserving the past. Nevertheless, he was in touch with the future. He worked as the town auditor in Stowe, Vermont, where he had a vacation house. This was a volunteer position requiring a month’s labor every winter. He also, on a largely volunteer basis, managed the town offices, transitioning them all to the computer.

At eighty-three, Boatwright was still working twenty-eight hours a week: “I’m pushing nonprofits to be all they can be. . . . I’m the guy who says we have to try.” The hope of men like Mandela and Boatwright springs eternal. At eighty-five he believed that his most creative activity was “to inspire people to see all sides of a problem”—a hallmark of wisdom.

By the time he was eighty-nine there was no doubt that Boatwright was an old man. He still exercised two hours a day, but cross-country skis and tennis racquets had been given away; now he contented himself with slow walking. He admitted that he felt tired and was plagued with minor ailments: two bad knees, two bad shoulders, shingles, cataracts, and ankle edema. But he still took no medicines and called his health “excellent.” When asked what he did now that he hadn’t done a decade ago, he growled, “A hell of a lot less!” He had reduced his volunteer work to three hours a week, spending his time instead with his grandchildren, and visiting shut-in and dying friends. The task of Integrity is not to set the world on fire, but to come to terms with reality and maintain one’s sense of life in the face of death. At age ninety Charles Boatwright is still very much alive.

Psychologist Laura Carstensen and her Stanford colleagues have documented that in late life emotions often take the place of thinking. 22 As Boatwright explained it to Batalden, “With age, you acquire more understanding. The things you felt so passionate about when you are young, you learn to let go of. You realize that all those things you thought you were going to be, you ain’t. As I have often said, at this stage in life it’s not what you’ve accomplished in a day, but how the day felt.”

A questionnaire when the men were about seventy-six asked what they were proudest of, and what they wanted to be remembered for. Boatwright’s response: “I don’t give a damn if I’m remembered for anything. I’ve enjoyed my life and had a hell of a good time. I’m more proud of those times I’ve helped others.” He added at eighty-three, “I know I’m a Pollyanna, but it’s better than being a pessimistic grouch.” Maybe Pollyanna and Aristotle have something in common on the subject of the good life. And maybe the fans of “selfish” genes are selling Mother Nature short.

Boatwright knew how to love and to work. He was capable of a long and happy marriage, and could look tenderly after the well-being of children (and others) in need of his care. He was truly gifted in the mature adaptational device of sublimation, and he seemed to be ever more absorbed, as he grew older, in explicitly spiritual rather than worldly fulfillment. When asked what he had learned from his children, Boatwright replied without hesitation, “Oh my gosh, an infinite amount. Much, much more than they’ve learned from me, I’m sure. . . . They keep me up to date; they keep me young. I’m infinitely grateful to them for keeping me on the positive side of life.” So there’s that question again. Are compassion and gratitude Pollyannaish? Or are they the beginning of wisdom? A paradox, a paradox, a most ingenious paradox! But Professor Monika Ardelt, who has been studying wisdom for years, identified him as the wisest man in the Study, and she should know. Certainly her identification, which called him belatedly to my more respectful attention, had a hand in raising my own wisdom quotient, too.

Boatwright’s story brings up another aspect of adult development—both mine and the men’s. When I was thirty-three, most of the Study men looked depressed to me. In fact they were not clinically depressed, but at age forty-seven they had

become comfortable about acknowledging their depressed emotions. I had not. Yet. Age has long been observed to be a factor in emotional experience, even outside of the context of healthy development. In manic-depressive psychosis, for instance, mania often dominates the picture in the years between twenty and thirty, while between forty and fifty the depressive component is more prominent. Delinquents and addicts tend to be more able to admit previously denied depression into consciousness after the age of forty, feeling it instead of acting it out or projecting their emotional pain. The same pattern occurred with the maturation of normal men in the Grant Study.

Their capacity to tolerate more conscious depression in midlife than earlier in their lives (or than I could as a still-young man) meant that they were also less incapacitated by the frustrations of life, their own and others'. What had happened to permit such changes? When I was forty, I attributed them to maturing defense mechanisms. Later I learned (from Washington University developmentalist Jane Loevinger, who collaborated with the Study for a time) that the ability to pull differentiated emotions up into awareness is another marker of ego development. ²³ Advances in brain science now suggest that the biological capacity to bring emotional valence into consciousness matures as the brain's tracts become more efficiently insulated (better myelinated) with increasing age. ²⁴ In fact, what we understand as maturation depends, in part, on this fact of brain physiology, which allows better integration of the "emotional" subcortical brain with the "planful" frontal cortex. Is there any reason to dismiss any of these considerations? I don't think so. I grow older and wiser, and science does, too.

Over the last thirty years there has also developed an increasing awareness that people become less—not more—depressed between fifty and eighty. ²⁵ Selective attrition probably accounts for some of the declining prevalence of depression, but it is also due in part to what Laura Carstensen has called socioemotional selectivity: that is, the tendency of the old to remember the pleasant in favor of the unpleasant. ²⁶ The lives of the Grant Study men support that theory. If Adam Newman had remained twenty years old all his life, he would have been a basket case at the end of it.

WHEN PEOPLE DON'T GROW

What happens, however, when people don't accomplish Erikson's life tasks? What happens to adults who, as they grow older, fail at work and at love, or who are trapped in unempathic, isolating coping styles?

Peter Penn was one of those. He was married for almost forty-five years; he was a tenured professor of English; he published a book in his field. And yet he never really entered the world of adulthood; in most ways he never left home. He didn't meet the criteria for depression, but there is no evidence that he ever felt joy. This is his story. It's a sad one. Developmental failure is always sad.

Penn was a frightened little boy. Until he was seven, he couldn't fall asleep without his mother in his room. He was very inhibited; the closest to profanity that he ever came, by his mother's report, was a slip of paper in his high-school knickerbockers that said, "Gosh dang it." His mother actually confronted him about this, and he explained that he had been furious at his teacher, and had written the words to dissipate his rage.

His childhood was very bleak. His mother was a nervous worrier, and his father a very distant man. Nevertheless Peter was president both of his church group and of his seventh-grade class. That was perhaps his finest hour. Once puberty began, his emotional growth ceased. I have no good explanation for this. One colleague has suggested undiscovered abuse, and another has wondered if perhaps Penn was a closeted homosexual. But there's no evidence for either of these suppositions; they are facile speculations and they tell us less about Penn than about how easy—and tempting—it is to manufacture theories after the fact.

There was nothing the matter with his intelligence. Fascinated by religion and by history, he majored in American history and literature—an elite major. His father had attended business college, and his mother was a high school graduate, but neither cared much for reading. Still, Penn planned to become an English professor.

In college, he seemed to lack a sense of identity and even a life narrative. He could not describe his relationships with his parents; when asked to describe himself, he could only tell stories, and they mostly didn't involve him. Interviewers wrote, "He was pleasant, cheerful and extremely boring," and "He was passive in the way a sponge is passive." He remained that way as an adult—passive and very dependent. The zest for life that makes our adolescent children want to leave even loving parental homes was not in Peter Penn's repertoire.

Lewis Gregory described the sophomore Penn as “ponderous and lumbering.” His college life was barren. The literary magazine *The Advocate* didn’t offer him a position on the staff. He did no dating because, he explained, he was “too busy” and had “no car or money.” He didn’t like dances, and had few friends. He did not take part in sports. Like Sam Lovelace he had a high resting pulse rate. His only activity was the Glee Club.

Penn won writing prizes and graduated magna cum laude; even so, Harvard’s Graduate School of Arts and Sciences turned him down. He was one of only six Grant men who finished the war as a private, and he returned from World War II with a good conduct medal.

After the war, he returned to his hometown to pursue a Ph.D. in English. At thirty he confessed, “It is so easy to live at home and eat Mother’s cooking.” Like many second-year graduate students, he became a teaching assistant in a freshman basic writing course. The scholarly essays that he submitted to academic journals were not accepted. He wasn’t mentally ill. He never saw a psychiatrist; he took no mood-altering drugs. He just remained essentially what he had been in seventh grade—a good and not very imaginative seventh-grader.

He was unadventurous in other ways, too. At twenty-nine he explained, “Some honest doubts, unpropitious circumstances, and perhaps a bachelor’s wariness have prevented me from facing up to the question of marriage. . . . My relations with women are more satisfying socially than sexually. . . . I can rationalize my single state by pleading the comfort and security of life at home.” At thirty-two he had still never had a serious girlfriend. His mother was the one with whom he talked about personal problems. At age thirty-five, his thesis still incomplete, he had to leave his university for a community college, and he stopped answering questionnaires until his twenty-fifth reunion year.

When Penn began returning questionnaires again at age forty-seven, the Study learned that he had finally received his Ph.D. at thirty-seven, and had married the same year, still a virgin. His wife was five years older than he. Penn acknowledged that they fought all the time: “Her attacks on me are so savage they reduce me to tears. . . . I think I love my wife.” Ouch. Despite all his years of marriage, the Study never gave Penn credit for completing the task of Intimacy. Although he and his wife remained stably together, there was no evidence that Penn enjoyed his marriage any more than he did his students or anything else, and he spoke about his wife as if he had finally married the mother he had lived with for so long. (His mother died when he was forty-three.)

The acquisition of his doctoral degree did not add to Penn’s excitement about his career. When he took early retirement thirty years later, he recognized to his dismay that he had spent his whole teaching life in almost exactly the same entry-level job—teaching remedial writing. He was unhappy at work, and never in his life did he express any pleasure in teaching. What Penn liked best about his teaching job was its “tenure and security.” He preferred small classes because they were less work.

During his fifties, Penn took a lot of sick days. He was hospitalized three times, but no problems were ever discovered. He published his thesis as a book. It sold a few copies and was then remaindered; Penn bought fifty copies himself. It received no attention and has long been out of print.

Penn retired early, at sixty-three. His most frequent daydream was that he might yet do something of importance. But what? He had no interests or hobbies, only hope. He still remembered his pre-teen days as the happiest of his life. His sister lived in an adjoining state, but they hadn’t seen each other for two years, and he hadn’t seen his best friend in three. When I visited Penn for his retirement interview at sixty-five, he rarely made eye contact. He lectured to me impersonally about this and that, but pedantically and without charm. His social skills had apparently not improved since he was a sophomore.

In setting up the interview, Penn had told me that he needed to ask “Mrs. Penn” if I could come to visit. “We live between frustration and despair,” Agatha Penn quipped as she (reluctantly, I thought) opened the door to me, and she pointed to two prints dedicated to those painful topics hanging on their living room wall. She didn’t laugh, however, and she avoided me for the rest of the time I was there, unlike many of the wives of my experience who—out of friendliness or curiosity or both—made their presence known from time to time with coffee or cookies.

Penn told me that he had retired out of “disillusionment.” After years of teaching remedial English in an inner-city commuter college, “I got a little fed up.”

“I have a very good singing voice,” Penn told me, “but since I married, I have kept my voice on ice.” His wife had been jealous of his accompanist. It was also she, it seemed, who had forbade him to return many of the Study questionnaires.

When Professor Peter Penn died at eighty-one of cancer, he had been happier for the first half of his life, living with his mother, than he had ever managed to be in the second half. He always worked hard, and like an obedient Boy Scout or soldier he never did anything to endanger his good-conduct awards. He did not abuse alcohol or cigarettes. He stayed married for forty-four years and spent his life teaching disadvantaged college kids. But his first year of junior high school was the high point of his life, and the closest that he ever came to Identity. What happened? Penn’s college adjustment was A. There was never a hint of depression, either in his heredity or in his life. His ancestral longevity was in the top 15 percent of the College sample. Yet his score on the Decathlon was 1. The only clue—and the clue itself is a mystery, as I’ll discuss in Chapter 10—is that his maternal grandfather died very young. Despite superior ambition, excellent verbal skills, a fine singing voice, a deep wish to be a scholar, and the possession of 8,000 books, he could find no purpose or meaning in his life, professionally or otherwise. He just never grew up. A tragedy. Reviewers have called me heartless and unempathic for publishing such an unhappy tale. But I offer it not out of lack of compassion, but to show convincingly how tragic developmental failures really are.

For a long time that was the end of Peter Penn’s story, as far as I knew it. But in April 2012, as I was readying this manuscript for the publisher, I discovered by chance that Penn had written a series of poems to his wife, and that she had underwritten their publication many years after his death. I raced home with the book, wondering (hopefully, this time) if continued follow-up would once again prove me wrong. Alas, it did not. These poems were loving, but they might have been written by a sixteen-year-old with a stiff upper lip. After ten years of marriage he had said, “Her attacks on me are so savage they reduce me to tears. . . . I think I love my wife.” And by the book’s testimony, little had changed. For forty-four years Penn wrote ritual poems to his wife on birthdays, anniversaries, holidays, and Valentine’s Day. They say nothing about the relationship between them, only about his thoughts and wishes, and his unquenchable hope that if he just said the word “love” often enough it might come true. I was moved by his hope and by evidence of this unexpected mastery of sublimation as a coping style. But hope is not always enough. Nelson Mandela and Charles Boatwright used indomitable hope to get out of prison. Peter Penn used it to bear an endless incarceration.

THE LIFE OF BILL DIMAGGIO

Consider the contrasting life of one of the men of the Inner City cohort, Bill DiMaggio. He came from an “underclass” family; as a child he had shared a bed with his brother in an apartment without central heating. His father, a laborer, had been disabled since DiMaggio was a teenager, and his mother died when he was sixteen. With a Wechsler Bellevue IQ of 82 and a Stanford reading IQ of 71, Bill completed ten grades of school with difficulty.

Nevertheless, at age fifty, Bill DiMaggio was a charming, responsible, and committed man. If he was short and noticeably overweight around the midsection, he still retained plenty of youthful vigor. His face was expressive; there was a twinkle in his eyes; and he had a good sense of humor and a healthy appetite for conversation. He maintained eye contact easily and answered questions directly and frankly. He told his interviewer that by consenting to be a continuing part of the Study, he felt that he was contributing something to other people; he felt that this “little thing” was important.

For the first fifteen years of his adult life, DiMaggio worked as a laborer for the Massachusetts Department of Public Works. When a position opened for a carpenter, he got it by seniority. He didn’t have any carpentry skills, but he learned them on the job. “I like working with my hands,” he said. Now he took special pride in his role in maintaining some of Boston’s historic and antique municipal buildings.

Asked how he handled problems with people at work, DiMaggio replied, “I’m the shop steward in the union, so they lay off me. I’ll stand up to them if I feel I’m right.” If he thought that a job was dangerous, for example, he would not allow his men to work on it. Under union rules, management had to listen to him, and he had learned to speak with authority.

His bosses had been trying to get along better with him over the last year, too, DiMaggio explained. He was one of the few really experienced men on the job, and they were depending on him more. Management also depended on his experience to help teach other men; DiMaggio had a lot of responsibility. (The Study has found that after the age of 40,

IQ as measured by a school-oriented test like the Wechsler Bellevue does not count for much, and DiMaggio was an excellent illustration of this.) But, he continued, “It’s only a job. I’m more concerned about my wife and kids. Once I leave work I forget about it.”

He was in fact very interested in family matters. He described taking his sons on fishing and other trips as they were growing up. “We spent a lot of time together.” His own father—chronically unemployed—had never taken him fishing or gone out with him much.

Asked what his greatest problem had been with his children’s growing up, DiMaggio replied with a smile, “Do you have about six months?” But he added seriously, “Being worried about drugs.” He knew that his kids smoked marijuana; and he said he and his wife could accept that. But they would not let them smoke in their house. They accepted the fact that their youngest son had moved in with his girlfriend, and they made no moral judgments about it. They chalked it up to his being “very immature,” and felt that he would become more mature as time went on. One vital ingredient of Generativity is hope, but hope is only possible if one’s mind can encompass the concept of development. Bill DiMaggio’s greatest ambition in the next ten years was to see his children living independently. The capacity to accept a generative balance between care and letting go requires a lot of maturity of one’s own.

DiMaggio belonged to the Sons of Italy. He was quite active in that organization, and he regularly helped out with Bingo night, which meant running games for all the women who came on Wednesdays to play. He and another member, a friend, regularly cooked for the club’s Saturday morning lunches. DiMaggio enjoyed that; he liked people being happy with his food. Through the Sons of Italy, he also did volunteer community work. On the Fourth of July he helped host a big party for the kids in the neighborhood, with games and refreshments, and he was active in various other club activities for children throughout the year.

DiMaggio and his wife had signed up to work for a candidate who was challenging the old-guard city boss for mayor. And he was active in the “Council of Organizations,” an umbrella organization for the charitable clubs in Boston’s North End. This socially and intellectually limited schoolboy had matured into a leader of leaders, a wise man, and a Guardian.

You don’t need a Harvard degree, or even a high IQ, to grow up into a mensch, to do your bit for the next generation, to work in community building. Nor do career and family commitments have to conflict. Sadly, DiMaggio died young from a heart attack.

CATERPILLARS AND BUTTERFLIES

In 1980, when I was forty-five, I wrote with presumptuous authority that maturity is not a moral imperative.²⁷ At that time, my motto for the Grant Study was that life is a journey, not a footrace, and that butterflies are neither better nor healthier than caterpillars. The men had to develop for three more decades, and I had to gather a lot more data and experience of life before I could contradict in my late seventies what I believed twenty years before. But now I do. Peter Penn and the other men like him endured lives of desperation, whether quiet or not. The Terman women who failed to master Generativity were only one third as likely to be orgasmic as those who had. There is a time for being a caterpillar, but it is brief. Psychosocial maturity may not be a moral imperative, but its lack is very painful.

And it is a matter of life or death. In 2011, only four of the 31 Grant Study men who failed to mature past Erikson’s stage of Intimacy are still alive. Fifty of the 128 men who reached Generativity are—a very significant difference. In fact, the Generative died eight years later on average than those who never mastered Career Consolidation. The men who achieved Generativity were three times as likely to be enjoying their lives at eighty-five than men whose lives were still centered on themselves. Adult development is not just a descriptive convention; it is part of healthy growth.

Furthermore, much of the joy in adult life grows out of these developmental accomplishments. At least for these men, to fail at Intimacy implied other painful lacks. In the Inner City cohort, two-thirds of the never-married were in the bottom fifth in overall social relations, 57 percent were in the bottom fifth in income, and 71 percent were classified by the Study raters as mentally ill.

Some men took their developmental steps late. Occasionally this turned their lives around sufficiently that they lived long and died content. Certainly late is better than never, and many of the advantages that the Cherished enjoy in young adulthood can become available to the Loveless grown old—if they can learn in the meantime how to find love. Still,

these men spent lonely and sometimes wretched years in the waiting. And although there's no statute of limitations on development, some specific opportunities—to have children, for instance—do not wait forever.

DEVELOPMENT THWARTED: THE LIFE OF ALGERNON YOUNG

Maturation is not an inevitable byproduct of aging; it can be derailed. Drought can blight ripening wheat; corkage can destroy a fine Bordeaux; shin splints can turn a Derby prospect into a shambling nag. An organic insult to the brain can destroy or reverse the normal maturational process and leave an individual an insecure youth forever. Major depression, alcoholism, and Alzheimer's disease are the most common culprits. But they aren't the only ones. A certain amount of good luck is involved in growing old without accident, disease, or social catastrophe. The more we know about ideal development, the more easily we can recognize the forces that hinder or disrupt it, and possibly counteract them.

The life of Algernon Young is a cautionary tale, a sharp reminder of the vulnerability of developmental processes and of the pain of an undeveloped life. Young was a gifted man, well loved, from a family that the original Study staff had ranked as upper class. (Judge Holmes's family had been ranked as upper-middle.) Young started out with everything going for him. He was not an alcoholic. Yet his outcome was poor, and much of his life was misery. He is one of the Study's best rebuttals to the argument that Oliver Holmes's money ensured his success.

Young's mother grew up socially privileged, and her father was a sixth-generation Harvard alum. His father was a Harvard grad, and through Algernon's childhood he was the headmaster of a Denver prep school.

Algernon's mother depicted a cheerful and competent childhood. Her son was "a grown man when he was two years old," she said—a haunting description, given how things turned out. "The children adore each other," she told Miss Gregory, "and have always gotten on well." Algernon attended his father's school, where he did well academically and was one of the leaders of the student body.

His intellectual gifts were as great as any man's in the Grant Study, and like Peter Penn he received an A on psychological soundness from his college raters. Miss Gregory thought he had "good social ability," and so did the Study psychiatrist, who judged him "well-adjusted socially." His college summary noted that "he has no conflict with his parents. . . . His early life was happy and, for the most part, he was a member of the group." Only Clark Heath saw him as immature; he did not say how.

But when Young was twenty-nine, the Study anthropologist noticed that he was still "closely tied to his mother, unwilling to make new associations." From thirty to thirty-seven he dated a woman who was a heavy drinker; he proposed to her, but she turned him down. At forty-two he finally got married. His new wife was still attached to a high-school sweetheart of whom her parents had disapproved. Three years after her wedding to Algernon her mother died, and she ran off with her old love. At forty-nine Young was single again, and living just a few blocks from his parents. His life revolved around his pets, who kept him "too busy" for other relationships. "Catering to six cats can be a big affair," he explained. He found engagement with other people demanding and frightening; when he had to move outside his tiny circle of work and family (and sometimes within it, too) he deployed the coping style of an obsessional: isolation of affect, reaction formation, and displacement. His social life consisted of waving to fellow commuters in their cars.

Young's work life was no more satisfying than his personal life. At twenty-nine he wrote, "The brevity of my answers leads me to believe that my life must have been pretty substandard. It still may be. . . . My fondness for my current work has grown less. I seem to be stuck in a rut."

When he was in college, Young had wanted to be an automotive engineer. But he never rose above a low-paying position in a Denver heating and plumbing firm. In thirty-five years there, his greatest responsibility—installing furnaces—never changed. He took pleasure in his job only because he could build things, which had been one of the pleasures of his childhood. He told one interviewer in detail and with real enthusiasm about furnaces, but he communicated no pride in or commitment to his work role, and no sense of connection to the people he worked with.

At forty-six, when classmates far less privileged and intellectually gifted than he were firmly established in the upper middle class, Young wrote, "I feel deeply inadequate. . . . I have always felt that I could never sell myself." At fifty, he remained unpromoted and discontented. He was still working twelve hours a day, and often on Saturdays. His work was

“the same old rat race,” and his earned income was the lowest in the Study. At sixty, after thirty-five years at it, he said that what he liked best about his job was “the good benefits and the lack of stress.”

For a very long time Young did not involve himself in any community service—or indeed, in any community. His philosophical rationale for this at fifty was, “I know I can’t be my brother’s keeper,” but it appeared to me that in fact he felt too perpetually out of control in his own life to feel safe extending his attention beyond it. This of course reduced even further any chance of his establishing supportive relationships. He was asked on a questionnaire what contributions he had made that would benefit others. “If there is one, I can’t imagine what it would be,” he responded. In mid-adulthood, he was not advancing in his job, and he was too overwhelmed to emerge from self-absorption toward Generativity.

I met Algernon Young when he was forty-seven, two years after his wife had left him. I was struck by the contrast between his Brooks Brothers tweed jacket with the stylish leather patches at the elbows and his cheap shoes and workingman’s hands. Like Heath, I felt that he was immature. He was one of only two Grant Study men who felt continuously overwhelmed by bills, and he told me that he ate alone in diners. He acted like a deferential prep-school boy being interviewed by a teacher, while in fact he was fourteen years my senior.

What stunted the development of Algernon Young after such a promising adolescence? The answer seems to have been a one-two punch of tragic fate. When Young was eleven, his mother was psychiatrically hospitalized for crippling anxiety. Her symptoms turned out to be due to hyperthyroidism, and after thyroid surgery they never recurred. But her temporary loss of control was enough of a shock to Algernon that he quit believing in God. And then, when he was halfway through college, the other shoe dropped.

This time it was his father who was hospitalized, and the circumstances were terrible. After twenty-five years of loyal service to his school, he was fired, and a whiff of scandal attended the firing, concerning a possible mismanagement of funds. The facts were that a major depression had compromised his ability to handle the complex responsibilities of his office.

Like his mother, Algernon’s father recovered from his depression and obtained a prestigious job at another school. But the son never recovered. For the rest of his life he felt (as Willy said about the death of his father in *Death of a Salesman*) “kind of temporary about myself.” Algernon Young seemed to have lost all faith in everything, including himself. As gifted in math as he was, the moment his father began having trouble handling the school finances, he failed algebra. Then he dropped out of Harvard. He took a job in a factory to support his family, and never returned to college. All of his positive college ratings were made before the Study accepted that he was never coming back.

In our forty years of follow-up we saw no evidence of major depressive disorder in Young himself. Nor did he ever seriously abuse alcohol. He just kept away from people and confined himself to the rational predictability of furnaces. His parents’ sequential abandonments under such frightening circumstances seem to have left him trapped in a fearful need; he couldn’t trust them any longer, yet he wasn’t ready to let them go enough to form new relationships where trust was possible. He tried in his first marriage, only to be abandoned again. At age forty-nine, Young could still say, like a ten-year-old boy, “My main interest is in things mechanical.”

It is not only changes in ourselves that drive us to essay new roles; our interactions with others transform us too. But maturational transformations take place from within. They are the fruit of internalization and identification, not of instruction or even socialization. They happen only when we can metabolize, as it were, those influential others, taking them into ourselves in a profoundly intimate and structural way. There’s a world of difference between knowing something in one’s head and knowing it in one’s gut. When internalization does not take place, one of our main avenues of growth is foiled. As a child Algernon Young was given plenty of love, but after the twin catastrophes of his youth—which, however innocent and inadvertent, must have felt to him as twin failures of the two most important people in his life—he seems to have developed an emotional malabsorption syndrome—he could no longer take anything in. His identificatory capacity gave out in his mid-teens, and so did his growing. Young did not have Asperger’s syndrome, but the jury is still out on the other possible causes of his failure in maturation. It appears that he stopped being able to make use of the love that came his way; contrast his life course with that of Godfrey Camille, who was given so little love at the beginning that even the usually nurturing Grant Study staff dismissed him as a “regular psychoneurotic.” Yet Camille left no stone unturned until he found the love he needed, and then he absorbed it greedily.

When Young was fifty, one of his very few friends died. He told the Study that he had lost a piece of himself, and added, “Do not ask for whom the bell tolls; it tolls for thee.” He was addressing a question that more usually preoccupies those who survive into old age: How, over the long years of the adult lifespan, are losses replaced? How do we face the losses that we can never replace? But Young wasn’t old. He was only fifty, and he had stopped growing at eighteen.

In his later years Young’s life improved somewhat, and by the time he died he had technically met my criteria for Intimacy and partial Career Consolidation. His renaissance began at fifty-one, when he gave up the agnosticism he had maintained since the early days of his mother’s troubles and rejoined his parents’ church. Probably through the church, Young met and married a widow with two children. When his mother died three years later he coped well, despite his prior dependence on her. His second marriage endured until he died at sixty-six, but it was the partners’ mutual involvement with their church that gave it substance. Study men with richer professional lives and more grandchildren often grew away from the church. But men who were needful of connection late in life sometimes sought it in religious affiliation. 28 Looking back, it appeared at first as though Young was returning to the point of crisis, allowing his mother and father to become sources of identification once more, and resuming, slowly, his own truncated development. Certainly the death of parents may release fresh growth in adult life. But even that hope would not be fully realized for the timid Algernon Young.

While Camille, newly returned to his church, gave communion to housebound parishioners and befriended the entire congregation, Young headed straight for the account books and became the (unpaid) church treasurer. At fifty-eight, as a born-again evangelical Baptist, he wrote the Study, “My God has supplied my needs material and otherwise.” At sixty-four he told the Study, “My labor of love to the Lord is being treasurer for the First Baptist Church,” which, he explained, was his greatest interest in life. He was still primarily interested in “mechanical” things. By the time he died at sixty-six, he could finally write, “I am a success with my family.” Camille at the end of his life fell in the top third of the Decathlon, but Young, like Lovelace, received a 0. Admittedly, Camille had had fourteen more years in which to develop.

THE LAST YEARS

At age seventy-five, the College men were asked to define what they considered wisdom to be. Here are some of their definitions.

“Empathy through which one must synthesize both care and justice.”

“Tolerance and a capacity to appreciate paradox and irony even as one learns to manage uncertainty.”

“A seamless integration of affect and cognition.”

“Self-awareness combined with an absence of self-absorption.”

“The capacity to ‘hear’ what others say.”

We also asked these seventy-five-year-old parents of the Sixties Generation a provocative question: “Taboos on obscenity, nudity, pre-marital sex, homosexuality, and pornography seem to be dead or dying. Do you believe this is good or bad?” We often received black and white answers. But one Episcopalian minister wrote: “NEITHER. What human beings need are limits to their behavior and freedom to realize their true selves—we really need a societal consensus on limits balanced with freedoms. I think these limits and freedoms and the balance between them change with the culture.” He had put aside absolute convictions about faith, morality, and authority in favor of a new appreciation of their relativity and mutability.

But remember, he was seventy-five when he wrote that reply. In his younger years, according to his daughters, he had been more judgmental. As we mature, we learn from experience how important a dimension Time is, and how profoundly it determines the shape of our reality. As we understand the relativities and complexities of life more deeply, the immature need to believe becomes a mature capacity to trust, and religious ideology makes room for spiritual empathy.

Students of late-life development, like Jane Loevinger at Washington University in St. Louis and Paul Baltes at the Max Planck Institute in Berlin (who was a pioneer in wisdom research), share views very similar to that minister’s. 29 Loevinger understands the most mature phase of adult development (which she calls Stage 6 or Integrated) to be characterized by tolerance of ambiguity, reconciliation of inner conflict, and the ability to cherish another’s individuality

while respecting 30 For Baltes, it was “an awareness that all judgments interdependence are a function of, and are relative to, a given cultural and personal value system. 31

Sociologist and colleague Monika Ardelt, who brought Charles Boatwright to my attention as the wisest of the Grant Study men, has spent her professional life trying to operationalize Baltes’s views. 32 Ardelt examined personality inventories that the men had taken in 1972 and 2000 (see Chapter 3), and derived from the results three components that she considers intrinsic to wisdom and essential to it. 33 These were: the cognitive capacity to grasp the deeper significance (both positive and negative) of transient phenomena; the reflective capacity to consider issues from multiple perspectives; and the affective capacity to care deeply about the well-being of others. 34 Thus measured, wisdom correlated with maturity of defenses and absence of mental illness at midlife, with close friendships, and with late-life adjustment.

CONCLUSION

Ultimately, to age successfully is to transcend decay. The task of Integrity is to retain human dignity despite the ravages of mortality. This is not a task particular to old age; it is the developmental challenge of all those who face imminent death. At fifty-two, Grant Study member Dr. Eric Carey knew already that he was doomed to an early death from complications of polio. From his wheelchair he articulated the challenge that faced him: “The frustration of seeing what needs to be done and how to do it but being unable to carry it out because of physical limitations . . . has been one of the daily pervading problems of my life in the last four years.” But three years later, he had answered his own challenge: “I have coped . . . by limiting my activities (occupational and social) to the essential ones and the ones that are within the scope of my abilities.” To be able to honor life’s essentials and simultaneously bow to its realities is Integrity in a nutshell.

At fifty-seven, Dr. Carey told the Study that the last five years had been the happiest of his life: “I came to a new sense of fruition and peace with self, wife and children.” He spoke of peace, and his actions portrayed it. He understood that, whenever possible, legacies (both concrete and metaphoric) should be bestowed before death.

At sixty-two, he talked about the risky anesthesia he had recently required for an operation. “Every group gives percentages for people who will die: one out of three will get cancer, one out of five will get heart disease, but in reality one out of one will die. Everybody is mortal.” He was dead a year later from pulmonary insufficiency.

As the Study member I quoted above pointed out, it’s the old who can teach us that life is worthwhile “to its very end.” That is a lesson that it took me, young and arrogant maven of adult development that I once was, thirty years to learn.